



Digital immortality

Will technology allow us to one day make the shift from a physical existence to an entirely digital one? <https://dgit.in/jun20-58>



Managing collective histories

An exploration of the ethics of how to handle the digital footprints left behind by the dead, at scale. <https://dgit.in/jun20-59>

FEATURE

Google data once your account becomes inactive. The period for that is set at 3 months after the account goes inactive, and cannot be changed.

OTHER ACCOUNTS

Facebook lets you pass on your account to a legacy contact after your death. The options are available in Settings > Memorialisation settings. This is simple enough to set up. You just have to add the profile of a person who will get access to some aspects of your account after you pass away. Your profile page will be converted into a memorial page, where people can post remembering your life. A person in control of the memorial page can choose who can post, who can view the posts, and even to delete the page. The individual you nominate has to have a Facebook account. Facebook has to be notified that your account has been memorialised, and does not do so automatically after detecting a period of inactivity. See box for the details on how to do that. Alternatively, you can just choose to delete your account and remove all your content from Facebook if someone reports your death, instead of letting your page be converted to a memorial page.

Microsoft does not provide options to manage what happens to your account after your death. You have to give your credentials to someone else, along with instructions. The accounts get deleted two years after they are last active. Outlook and OneDrive data get purged a year after they are last active.

Another service agnostic method to save details, is to use Lastpass, a password manager with a free tier. All your passwords can be saved into this single app or browser extension, and you can key in your PIN numbers as well. In the mobile app, go to Security > Emergency Access to set up what happens to your account in case you die. Here, you can nominate another Lastpass user to get access to all the passwords stored in your vault, in case you die. What happens is once you nominate someone, and

REPORT A DEATH TO SOCIAL NETWORKS

Here is how to let social networks know that a near or dear one has passed away. Note that these sites require proof in the form of death certificates or obituary articles.

- Facebook: <https://dgit.in/fblegacy>
- Instagram: <https://dgit.in/inlegacy>
- Twitter: <https://dgit.in/TwtrDem>

in case you die, that person can request access. Then, if you do not respond within a specific period, they get access to your vault. Bear in mind that only those you nominate beforehand can get access to your vault, not anyone who requests Emergency Access later. You can nominate someone's email id for Emergency Access, and choose a time period within which to reply before that person is provided access. This period ranges from 3 hours to 30 days. In case there are some critical things that need to be done quickly in case you are dead or cannot access your services, you can also set up Lastpass to give immediate Emergency Access. Keeper, RoboForm and Dashlane are password managers that all allow you to set up mechanisms to allow nominated people to allow access to all your accounts, as part of a paid service though.

TWO FACTOR AUTHENTICATION

For things like subscription services, access to bank accounts and any service that requires two factor authentication, it is a good idea to give a family member or a friend access to your phone. When planning for your death, it is a good idea to find a way to give someone else access to your phone as well. If your phone has a fingerprint scanner, it is possible to add their finger to the security setup as well. Another option is to send out an email using a dead man's switch to the ID of a person, with all the information they need to access all your accounts, as well as your phone.

A DEAD MAN'S SWITCH

Used in locomotives, a dead man's switch is a device that turns on the brakes in case pressure is not constantly provided to a certain button, handle or paddle. A digital version of the dead man's switch allows you to send emails, share details, and even post video messages in case you do not indicate to a service that you are still alive. These services can allow you to reach out to a large number of contacts, not just your trusted ones. One of the simplest and fastest to set-up is lastwords.rip, which also has a companion app. You have to respond to an email, or a notification periodically, failing which emails can be sent out to near and dear ones. You can upload up to 40 MB of content on the service. The service lets you attach videos, photos and voice messages as well. This email service can be used in tandem with Lastpass so that the same contact receives instructions on what to do with your digital legacy, and get control of your accounts at the same time.

The maximum period allowed for the switch is seven days, within which you have to login to the site or the app and click a button to inform the service that you are still alive. Failing to do so, a custom note along with the files will be sent to as many contacts as you add. My Goodbye Message is another service that works essentially in the same way. The Digital Beyond has a handy list of dead man's switches, both free and paid (<https://dgit.in/dgtlbynd>). Bear in mind that if you lose access to the internet, go into a coma, are imprisoned, or kidnapped then the messages you set up will be sent to everyone. It is a good idea to set up two switches, one nested within the other. One switch is for trusted contacts only with instructions on how to manage the switch for messages that reach more people. Lastwords.rip allows you to set up phases. In phase one, one set of contacts will be notified, while in phase two, a wider set of contacts will be notified.